

Lab: Planning a Crochet-Along

Group Activity — Planning

Objective

Plan a real crochet-along for your circle using Active Inference principles, applying expected free energy to choose a project, designing a temporal policy, and building in mechanisms for monitoring and adjustment.

Materials

- 3-5 printed crochet patterns of varying difficulty (the options to choose from)
- Large paper or whiteboard for planning
- Markers and sticky notes
- A calendar (physical or digital)
- Your current crochet projects (to work on during discussion)

Duration

60-75 minutes (this is a longer lab because it produces a real plan the group will follow)

Preparation

Before the meeting, one or two members select 3-5 potential crochet-along patterns. Try to include a range: - One simple option (known stitches, short timeline) - One moderate option (some new techniques, moderate timeline) - One ambitious option (significant new skills, longer timeline) - Optional: one wildcard (unusual technique, surprising project type)

Print or share the patterns so everyone can review them.

Activity Steps

Step 1: Evaluate Options Using Expected Free Energy (15 minutes)

For each pattern option, the group evaluates two dimensions:

Epistemic Value (learning): - How much will this project teach us? Score 1-5 on a sticky note.

- What new techniques will members learn? - Is the challenge appropriate for the group's current collective skill level?

Pragmatic Value (satisfaction): - How rewarding will the finished product be? Score 1-5 on a sticky note. - Does the project align with the group's preferences (practical items, decorative items, gifts)? - Will everyone be proud of the result?

Place all scores on the paper next to each option. Discuss: - Which option has the best balance of learning and satisfaction? - Are there disagreements? What drives them? (Different generative models will evaluate differently.) - Can you reach consensus, or does the group need a vote?

Choose the project together.

Step 2: Design the Temporal Policy (15 minutes)

Now plan the timeline. On the calendar or large paper, sketch out the weeks:

1. **Start date and end date:** How many weeks will the crochet-along last?
2. **Milestones:** Break the pattern into sections with target completion dates.
3. **Check-in points:** Which meetings will include a formal progress check?
4. **Buffer weeks:** Build in at least one "catch-up" week with no new progress expected.
5. **Help sessions:** When will the group dedicate time specifically to helping anyone who is stuck?

Discuss: - Is the pace realistic for the slowest member? For the busiest member? - What will you do if someone falls behind? (Policy updating) - What will you do if the pattern is harder than expected? (Collective prediction error response)

Step 3: Assign Roles and Resources (10 minutes)

Decide: - **Materials coordinator:** Who will help everyone source yarn and supplies? Can you order together for a discount? - **Pattern interpreter:** Who has the strongest pattern-reading skills and can help clarify confusing instructions? - **Encouragement officer:** Who will check

in on members between meetings (via group chat) to keep momentum? - **Documentation:**
Will you photograph progress? Keep a journal? Post on social media?

Notice how this role assignment maps to the agent structure of the circle — each person's generative model determines what they can contribute to the collective plan.

Step 4: Anticipate Prediction Errors (10 minutes)

As a group, brainstorm: What could go wrong? - Someone drops out or falls behind - The pattern has an error or is confusing - Gauge varies significantly between members - A member runs out of yarn - Life events interrupt participation

For each potential problem, discuss a response strategy. This is preemptive policy updating — building resilience into the plan by predicting likely prediction errors.

Step 5: Commit and Celebrate (5-10 minutes)

Finalize the plan. Each member states their commitment: - "I will start the foundation chain by next meeting." - "I will bring extra yarn in case anyone needs it." - "I will post a progress photo in the group chat each week."

Take a group photo to mark the beginning. The crochet-along is launched.

Reflection Prompts

- How did the group's evaluation of expected free energy differ between members? What does this tell you about the diversity of generative models in your circle?
- Was the planning process itself an example of collective active inference? Where did prediction errors arise even during the planning?
- How does having a plan make you feel about the project compared to starting without one?
- Revisit this plan after the crochet-along is complete. How closely did reality match the predicted trajectory?

Extension

At the end of the crochet-along, hold a retrospective meeting. Evaluate: - How well did the plan work? Where did the group need to update the policy? - What prediction errors occurred, and how were they handled? - What did the group learn — not just about crochet, but about planning together? - Use the retrospective to plan the next project more effectively. This is the circle's generative model for planning becoming more precise through experience.